

come into existence. In its current version, it offers nearly all the functionality of Google Desktop, minus sidebar and gadgets, and without the ability to check your Gmail.

AutoHotkey

www.autohotkey.com

If you've got mundane, repetitive tasks to perform—and who doesn't—AutoHotkey will let you do them using any keyboard shortcut of your choice. It lets you record keyboard and mouse activity and repeats it as many times as you'd like—much like macros in Word or Excel. It uses its own scripting language, and once you master it, you can create your own mini-applications that'll do anything you want them to—from replacing a string of characters with a phrase to looking up a highlighted word in the dictionary.

You don't really need to learn AutoHotkey's scripting language to get started—it comes bundled with AutoScriptWriter, which records the macros for you. One of the first things we do immediately after installing AutoHotkey is to assign Windows key shortcuts to our favourite applications—[Windows] + [O] becomes Opera, [Windows] + [Q] becomes Quake 3 and so on. Other such simple tasks follow, but to really tap AutoHotkey's capabilities, you'll need to learn the language—which, fortunately, is fairly easy to learn. You'll find a detailed tutorial here: <http://www.autohotkey.com/docs/Scripts.htm>.

Hotkeyer's Tip

If you're working on multiple PCs and want to take your scripts with you, you can compile them to make each script a standalone EXE—just right-click on a script and choose Compile Script! Once you've done this, you can run this EXE on any PC, so your shortcut or text replacement scripts can travel with you. They reside in the system tray, and ending them is as easy as right-click > Exit.

The Alternative

You can get your Windows key shortcuts with WinKey (<http://www.winkeymx.com/>), but there's really no alternative to AutoHotkey that even comes close to what it offers.

Winamp

www.winamp.com

It's easy to have forgotten about Winamp—after Windows Media Player (WMP) was finally able to manage your music library, many of us didn't look beyond. And, of course, there were problems with the program itself. Winamp 3 was a nightmare best not talked about and Winamp 5 didn't match the

performance of the original Winamp 2.8. Fire up the new Winamp 5.5, however, and we're impressed once again.

For one thing, Winamp's got a slick new interface, but still gives you the choice to use the original Winamp skin from way back when. The Music Library adopts the now standard three-pane interface (artists, albums and tracks) and lets you search for artists and songs in real time. You can double-click on songs to add them to the playlist—it doesn't sound like much, but this is a feature many loved in WMP 10 and sorely missed in WMP 11. You can even manage your video collection, apart from regular features like ShoutCast support. And then there's the one killer feature that sets it apart—GraceNote.



Song-hammer's Tip

We all have our share of files called Track01.mp3 by an artist we don't know, and quite often, these are songs we really like. With Winamp, thanks to a tie-up with GraceNote, you can now find out who sung this mysterious song. In Winamp's playlist, right-click on the file you want to identify and choose Send To > Autotag. Make sure you're connected to the Internet, and within seconds, you'll see all the song information you need. Apply the new ID3 tag and be on your way!

The Alternative

Yahoo! Music Jukebox (<http://music.yahoo.com/>)

Gmail Drive

www.viksoe.dk/code/gmail.htm

How much of your 6 GB (and growing) Gmail mailbox are you really using? Gmail Drive is a simple Windows shell extension that lets you use your Gmail inbox as online storage. You simply give it your Gmail username and password and you'll find another hard drive listed under My Computer. When you upload a file, it appears as a new e-mail in your inbox. To avoid the hassle of seeing a new e-mail every time you upload a file, you can create a filter in Gmail that archives all such mail (the subject line contains "GMAILFS").

It may not be the most extensive tool ever made, but Gmail Drive is the best way to use all that free space that Google has so generously given us all.



musicengine/; formerly MusicMatch Jukebox) is another media management tool we like—it's easy to use and does its job well. You can also use it to listen to LaunchCast radio stations, and it'll change your Yahoo Messenger status to show which song you're playing (should you choose this option). Only... it's purple. Purple.

Joost

www.joost.com

Simply put, Joost is free TV. If you've got a respectable broadband connection, you can download the Joost client and watch shows from all around the world, free of cost. Joost uses peer-to-peer (P2P) technology to get your video to you, so it's acceptably fast even on a 256 kbps connection. The video quality isn't anything worth raving about, but is not too bad—the price you pay for free access on a comparatively slow connection.

Joost gives you over 480 channels to watch; how many of those are actually worth watching, we leave to you to find out. The categories range from comedies to cartoons to documentaries and much more. You can even hack up your own channel by choosing your favourite shows and clubbing them together. The best thing about Joost is that it's completely on demand—you can watch whatever you want,



any time you want, and end the show if you're not enjoying yourself. Unfortunately, you must still deal with advertisements—that's how the company supports itself.

Viewer's Tip

Using Joost is pretty straightforward, so we'll take a moment here to recommend *Creature Comforts* under Cartoons & Animation.

The Alternative

Move along now, nothing to see here.

Free Download Manager

www.freedownloadmanager.com

Free Download Manager (FDM) is one of the most feature-packed download managers we've ever used. It's got all the essentials—the

CDBurnerXP

<http://cdburnerxp.se/>

We've become so used to the copies of Nero that come bundled with our CD or DVD writers that an alternative is almost unthinkable. CDBurnerXP gives you the same features that Nero Burning ROM does—burn data on to everything ranging from CDs to Blu-Ray discs, burn ISO images, create Audio CDs and so on. The interface is a friendly drag-and-drop affair, so you don't have to be an expert to use it.

At just 2.8 MB, CDBurnerXP doesn't waste space with fancy features and concentrates on what it does best – burn discs. This is one solid, straightforward tool that'll prompt you to uninstall the bloatware that Nero's become.

ability to split downloads, use different mirrors for the same file, download Flash videos from sites like YouTube, even BitTorrent support—and then adds a whole lot more. If you enable FDM's community features, you'll be able to see comments that users have left for each download—these comments can be quite helpful, steering you away from virus-infected downloads or telling you how to run an XP-only program under Vista. Another feature we like, is the ability to preview the contents of a ZIP archive and decide which files to download.

In its latest version, FDM also scans your PC's programs to see if you're running the latest version of everything—if you're not, FDM will download the necessary updates for you. It also sports a Web interface, so you can start downloads on your home PC from wherever you have Internet access.

If we were to gripe about anything, it'd be that FDM's clipboard monitor can get a bit over-enthusiastic sometimes—we can't count the number of times it's offered to download download.php for us.

Downloader's Tip

Always—and this applies to any download manager—change the number of simultaneous connections to a server to 10 by default. This'll make optimal use of your bandwidth, which really means that other applications won't have as much luck getting data from the Internet.

The Alternative

Orbit Downloader (www.orbitdownloader.com) has the same set of features, but doesn't integrate with Opera as well, and doesn't have the community goodness that FDM does. ☒

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